

Actuality, Self-Presence, and the Soul.

A Respectivist Account of Consciousness, Subjectivity, and Immortality

By PhilosophizingDoodle

Abstract

The hard problem of consciousness asks why physical processes are accompanied by subjective experience. Why should neural activity feel like anything from the inside? Respectivism proposes that this question arises from an ontological division that may never have existed in reality itself. Rather than treating physical processes and phenomenal experience as two separate things requiring a causal bridge, Respectivism begins with actuality as the foundational category from which both third-personal physical description and first-personal experience can be understood.

On this account, actuality is not merely a static state but an ordered reality possessing determinate capacities, relations, history, and possibilities. The relation between what an actuality is and what follows from its nature and circumstances constitutes an ontological is–ought structure. Subjectivity emerges when an actuality becomes organized around its own is–ought conditions: its states are not merely events occurring within it but states that matter to the being that undergoes them. As this organization becomes sufficiently unified and reflective, the actuality can enter into becoming consciousness. Consciousness is then not an additional substance or phenomenon produced by matter. It is the first-personal manifestation of actuality becoming directly present to itself.

This same framework provides a unified account of the soul. The soul is not a ghost hidden inside the body but the historically unified actuality of the person: the trajectory through which a being becomes who it is. Character is the direction taken by that trajectory, while reflective freedom is the capacity to participate in its further direction. Finally, Respectivism's account of time allows a distinctive conception of immortality. If past, present, and future events are equally real within a tenseless temporal order, then the past is not annihilated as it passes from present experience. Like a landscape viewed from a moving vehicle, the temporal world remains while the standpoint of the experiencing actuality changes. The history constituting a person therefore remains part of reality even when biological consciousness ends. Full immortality, however, requires more than historical persistence: it requires the divine preservation and fulfillment of that historical actuality through participation in Perfect Actuality.

Respectivism thus attempts to treat consciousness, subjectivity, personal identity, and immortality not as independent mysteries but as successive dimensions of one metaphysics of actuality, relation, and becoming.

1. The Hard Problem Begins with a Division

The hard problem of consciousness is usually formulated as a question about production.

The brain is a physical system. It contains neurons, synapses, electrical activity, chemical signaling, bodily feedback, and information-processing structures. Yet alongside this third-personally describable activity there appears to be something radically different: experience.

A person does not merely undergo neural activity. There is something it is like to feel pain. There is something it is like to see red, remember a childhood event, hear music, fear danger, or experience one's own body.

The apparent problem is therefore:

How does physical matter produce subjective experience?

Respectivism proposes that this question may begin too late.

It already assumes that there are two things:

a physical process, and an experience produced by that process.

The explanatory gap then appears almost inevitably. If physical reality is one kind of thing and experience another, what could possibly connect them?

Respectivism begins by questioning the division itself.

The physical brain state and the phenomenal experience may not be two independently existing entities. They may be two descriptions of one actuality under different modes of accessibility to the being.

From the outside, a particular state can be described in terms of neurons, electrochemical processes, causal relations, and information processing. From within that same organized actuality, the state may be experienced as pain.

The difference between the descriptions does not require a difference between the realities described.

This is the central ontological move of Respectivism:

Consciousness is not actuality producing an experience in addition to itself. Consciousness is actuality becoming directly present to itself.

The theory therefore does not attempt to build a bridge from "dead matter" to "magical experience." It attempts to show why the bridge may never have been necessary.

The deeper question becomes not how does matter produce consciousness?

Instead we should ask:

Under what conditions can actuality become present to itself?

2. Actuality as the Foundation

Respectivism begins with actuality.

Actuality is that which is fully determinate in itself and given as what it is, independent of partial or distorted modes of access. What is actual is what it does.

Anything that exists is actual in some respect. Before an entity is described as matter, organism, brain, mind, or person, there is the more basic fact that something is.

Yet finite actuality is never exhausted by a snapshot of what presently exists.

A seed is actually a seed while possessing the possibility of becoming a mature plant. A child is actually a particular person while possessing possibilities for learning, development, relationships, and action. An organism presently has a particular physical condition while possessing possibilities for recovery, injury, movement, reproduction, and death.

Actuality therefore exists within an ordered field of possibility.

This makes the familiar distinction between is and ought philosophically significant.

Respectivism does not initially mean "ought" in the specifically moral sense. It means the directed field of possibilities and requirements that follows from what an actuality is.

A living organism, for example, ought—in this ontological sense—to maintain conditions necessary for its continued existence. Food, water, temperature, injury, and threat are not merely external facts. They stand in different relations to the organism's nature and possibilities.

The is establishes the field of relevance within which the ought becomes intelligible.

This yields a fundamental principle:

What an actuality is determines, in part, what can matter to that actuality.

This is crucial for understanding subjectivity.

A rock and an animal can both be struck by an object. The event can be physically described in both cases. But the event does not stand in the same relation to the two actualities.

For an animal, injury can be something to avoid, something from which to recover, something threatening its continued existence. Its present condition stands within a field of possibilities belonging to itself.

The physical event has therefore acquired an internally significant relation to the actuality undergoing it.

This is the beginning of subjectivity.

3. Is–Ought as the Structure of Subjectivity

Subjectivity should not be understood as the mysterious appearance of a private observer.

It begins more fundamentally with the distinction between an event merely occurring and an event occurring for an actuality.

Pain provides the clearest example.

A damaged nerve can be described objectively. Neural signals can be measured. Patterns of activity can be mapped. Muscles can contract and behavior can change.

But pain is not merely information about tissue damage.

Pain is injury as it matters to the organism.

It has a directed character. It calls for avoidance, withdrawal, attention, protection, recovery, or action. It exists within the organism's field of possible continuation.

The important point is not that every conscious experience contains an explicit judgment such as "I ought to avoid this." The point is more fundamental: the experience is structured by the relation between the actuality's present condition and the possibilities inherent in its being.

Thus Respectivism places the is–ought distinction at the foundation of subjectivity.

The structure can be expressed as:

Actuality → *possibility* → *significance* → *subjectivity*.

An actuality becomes a subject insofar as its own states are organized in relation to what that actuality is and can become.

This also explains why subjectivity is inherently perspectival.

The same world can contain an event that is significant for one actuality and insignificant for another. Significance is not necessarily an additional property floating in the world; it can arise from the relation between an event and the being whose possibilities are affected by it.

Subjectivity is therefore not a departure from reality.

It is a particular organization of reality around an actuality's own existence.

4. From Subjectivity to Self-Relation

Subjectivity, however, is not yet reflective consciousness.

An organism can be organized around its own preservation and possibilities without explicitly recognizing itself as a self.

The transition to consciousness requires increasing internal unity.

Living organisms continuously integrate their internal conditions with their surroundings. They regulate themselves, respond to disturbances, maintain bodily boundaries, coordinate action, retain traces of previous states, and anticipate possible changes.

The organism therefore does not merely have relations.

Increasingly, its relations become relations within itself.

This creates the possibility of self-relation.

But self-relation must be distinguished from self-representation.

A thermostat can register its temperature. A computer can monitor its own memory usage. A sophisticated artificial system can construct a model of its own architecture.

None of these facts alone demonstrates consciousness.

Self-representation still leaves open the question:

Who experiences the representation?

If another observer is introduced behind the representation, the hard problem of consciousness has merely been moved backward. One would then have to explain how that observer experiences the second representation, and so on indefinitely.

Respectivism therefore rejects the need for a hidden observer.

The decisive condition is not merely that a system contains information about itself. It is that the actuality doing the relating and the actuality being related to are one and the same actuality.

This is direct self-relation.

The subject does not stand behind the experience and observe it.

The subject is the actuality whose own state has become directly present.

5. Consciousness as Self-Presence

This yields Respectivism's central account of phenomenal consciousness.

Consciousness is sufficiently unified actuality directly present to itself.

Suppose a person touches a hot surface.

From the third-person perspective, one can describe tissue stimulation, nociceptive signaling, neural processing, bodily reactions, memory, attention, and behavior.

From the first-person perspective, the person feels pain.

Respectivism does not posit a second event in which the physical processes somehow manufacture a separate experiential substance.

The physical description and the phenomenal description refer to the same organized actuality.

The difference lies in relation.

The scientist describes what the actuality is doing from outside.

The subject experiences what that actuality is undergoing from within.

This is why the phrase direct self-relation matters. If experience required a representation that was then observed by something else, the explanatory gap would remain. But if the actuality itself becomes present to itself, no further observer is necessary.

There is no little person inside the brain.

There is only the person.

This allows Respectivism to preserve both physical dependence and phenomenal reality. Consciousness can depend entirely upon physical organization without being reducible to a description that excludes its first-personal mode.

The brain does not manufacture a second thing called experience.

The organized brain is the actuality in which experience occurs because it is the actuality experiencing itself.

6. Why Is–Ought Matters to Phenomenality

Self-relation alone is not enough.

This is where the is–ought structure becomes essential rather than supplementary.

If consciousness were simply self-relation, then a sufficiently complex system might be conscious merely because it contained sufficiently sophisticated self-models.

Respectivism requires more.

The actuality must be related to itself as an actuality with its own history and possibilities.

The subject experiences its present state as its state.

Pain is not simply "damage detected."

It is damage occurring to me, within the field of possibilities that constitute my continued existence.

A threat is not merely a representation of an external object.

It is an alteration of my possible future.

A memory is not merely stored information.

It is part of my history.

A desire is not merely a computational output.

It is a possibility appearing within my field of becoming.

Therefore, the phenomenal character of consciousness—the fact that there is *something it is like* to be a particular being—arises neither from unity alone nor from the is–ought structure alone.

The is–ought structure gives an actuality an internally significant perspective: its states matter relative to what it is, what it has been, and what it can become.

Unity brings these significant relations together within one actuality. When that sufficiently unified actuality becomes directly related to itself, there is not merely information about a state, but the actuality's own condition becoming present from within its own field of significance.

Thus, what it is like to be something is the first-personal character of a sufficiently unified actuality encountering itself through its own directed possibilities and developing its own significance that belongs to its own unique slice of actuality.

The structure can now be stated more precisely:

Actuality → is–ought structure → subjectivity → internal unity → direct self-relation → phenomenal self-presence.

The is–ought structure explains why the self-relation is for the actuality rather than merely about it.

Self-relation explains the directness of consciousness.

Is–ought explains its subjectivity.

7. The Unity of Consciousness

This framework also provides a natural approach to the unity of consciousness.

Human experience ordinarily presents itself as unified. Vision, bodily sensation, memory, emotion, thought, and auditory experience are not encountered as independent consciousnesses that later happen to communicate.

They belong to one perspective.

Respectivism begins with the unity of the actuality rather than attempting to construct unity from separate experiences.

The order is therefore:

Unified actuality → unified self-relation → unified experience.

This reverses a familiar explanatory strategy.

Instead of asking how many separate neural events become combined into one consciousness, Respectivism asks how the neural events participate in one organized actuality whose self-relation is already unified.

The unity of experience is therefore not something added after the fact.

It follows from the unity of the self-relating actuality.

This also gives Respectivism a potential advantage over theories that begin with fundamental fragments of experience. The theory does not need to explain how many microscopic

experiences combine into one human subject because it does not posit those experiences at the fundamental level.

Actuality is fundamental.

Consciousness is not.

8. The Soul: History Becoming One

The same ontology that explains consciousness can be extended to personal identity.

What, then, is the soul?

Respectivism does not conceive the soul as a ghost hidden inside the body, nor as an invisible object located behind the eyes.

Nor is the soul identical with any single moment of consciousness.

The soul is the self understood historically.

A person is a continuing actuality whose present existence has been shaped by what has happened to it and by what it has done.

Every choice matters.

Every intention matters.

Every act of love, cruelty, courage, cowardice, sacrifice, failure, repentance, and transformation contributes to the trajectory through which the person becomes who they are.

These events are not merely information about the person.

They participate in constituting the person.

The soul can therefore be understood as:

the historically unified trajectory of an actuality becoming who it is.

This conception avoids two extremes.

The soul is not an independent substance that merely inhabits the body.

But neither is the self merely a sequence of disconnected conscious moments.

The person persists because there is continuity in the actuality through which those moments, actions, relationships, memories, and possibilities belong to one life.

The soul is history becoming one.

9. Character: The Direction of the Soul

The soul and character are therefore related but distinct.

The soul is the total historical trajectory of the person.

Character is the direction that trajectory takes.

A single choice rarely determines a person. Repeated choices, however, establish patterns. Patterns become habits, and habits increasingly constrain and enable future action.

Like water carving stone, becoming acquires form through repetition.

The person gradually develops a characteristic direction.

This means character is not primarily what a person says about themselves.

It is what their actuality has become disposed toward through participation in reality.

There is therefore a recursive relationship:

choice shapes character; character shapes future choice; future choice extends the soul's history.

This is where freedom enters the framework.

A reflective person can encounter not only the world but the direction of their own becoming. They can recognize their history, judge its direction, and attempt to alter what comes next.

Freedom is therefore not simply the absence of causal determination.

It is the capacity of a self-relating actuality to participate in the direction of its own becoming.

Character is the shape that this participation gradually gives to the soul.

10. Time: The Landscape Through Which the Self Travels

The account of the soul raises a deeper question.

If the soul is historical, what does it mean for events to become past?

Our ordinary experience makes time appear like a process of continual creation and destruction.

The present is real.

The past seems to disappear.

The future seems not yet to exist.

Respectivism instead adopts, as a metaphysical framework, a tenseless conception of time in which past, present, and future events are equally real.

The best analogy is a journey through a landscape.

Imagine sitting in a moving car.

As the vehicle travels, the landscape appears to move past you. A tree is first ahead, then beside you, and finally behind you. Your perspective continuously changes.

But the tree has not been created when you reach it, nor annihilated when you pass it.

The landscape remains.

What changes is your position within it.

Respectivism proposes that temporal passage can be understood similarly.

Events do not necessarily come into existence when they become present and cease to exist when they become past. Rather, a finite actuality undergoes a changing relation to an already ordered temporal reality.

This distinction allows two claims to be maintained simultaneously:

We genuinely experience temporal passage.

And the events through which we pass need not cease to be real merely because our perspective has moved beyond them.

The past is not unreal.

It is simply no longer the present relation of the traveling actuality.

11. The Past as Part of the Person

This has profound consequences for personal identity.

If the past remains real, then the history through which a person became who they are is not erased by becoming past.

A childhood event does not become nothing because adulthood arrives.

A sacrifice does not cease to have happened because the person later dies.

A relationship, a failure, a moment of courage, an act of cruelty, or an act of forgiveness remains an actual event within the temporal order.

This matters because the soul is constituted through history.

The past is therefore not merely a record stored somewhere outside the person.

It is part of the reality through which the person is what they are.

The person does not merely remember having lived.

They are the person who lived that life.

History is constitutive.

Consequently, when we speak of the soul as historical actuality, we are not speaking merely about memory or information. We are speaking about the ontological continuity of a life.

The soul is the trail left by becoming—but more precisely, it is the actuality constituted through that becoming.

12. Immortality: History That Cannot Simply Become Nothing

This provides the beginning of a Respectivist account of immortality.

The argument must be made carefully.

The reality of the past does not by itself prove that a person remains consciously alive after biological death. That stronger claim requires an additional theological premise.

What it does establish is something more modest and philosophically significant:

The reality of a person's history cannot be reduced to nothing merely because biological consciousness ends.

A life happened.

Its events are part of reality.

The actuality constituted through those events therefore has a history that cannot simply be rewritten into nonexistence.

Death may terminate the organism's present biological mode of self-relation. But it does not make the person's already-real trajectory as though it had never occurred.

The landscape does not disappear because the traveler can no longer see it.

This provides a metaphysical foundation for immortality without requiring the soul to be a detachable object.

The soul is not something that escapes the world.

The soul is the person whose history is already part of the world.

13. From Historical Persistence to Divine Fulfillment

Yet Respectivism should distinguish historical persistence from eternal life.

A past event can remain real without the person presently experiencing it.

If the theory is to support a stronger conception of immortality—one involving continued personal existence, consciousness, or resurrection—then theology must enter the argument.

Respectivism understands God as Perfect Actuality.

Finite beings possess unrealized possibilities. They depend upon conditions outside themselves. They develop through time and remain incomplete.

Perfect Actuality, by contrast, lacks unrealized potential. God is not one finite actuality among others but the fullness upon which finite actuality ultimately depends.

This creates a distinctive conception of salvation.

The finite person does not achieve immortality by escaping actuality.

Nor do they become immortal by ceasing to be the person they have become.

Instead, immortality consists in the preservation and fulfillment of the historical actuality that constitutes the person through participation in Perfect Actuality.

The finite trajectory is not discarded.

It is fulfilled.

This means that divine salvation, on this framework, is not fundamentally an escape from becoming. It is the completion of becoming.

God can take the actuality that a person has become through their history and bring that actuality into a fuller participation in divine life.

The person remains finite and distinct.

Perfect Actuality remains God.

But the creature's finite actuality can be brought into a relation with Perfect Actuality that exceeds the limitations under which it originally developed.

Immortality is therefore not the abandonment of the person's history.

It is its fulfillment.

14. Respect as the Order of Relation

Where, then, does Respect itself enter?

Respectivism should not make Respect synonymous with consciousness. Doing so would collapse the theory toward panpsychism.

Nor should Respect simply be defined as whatever makes consciousness possible, since that would make it explanatorily empty.

Respect is better understood as the fundamental relational order within which distinct actualities can exist, affect one another, develop according to their natures, and participate in a common reality without being reduced to one another.

This relational order makes possible the increasingly internal relations through which subjectivity and self-presence develop.

At the most basic level, actualities stand in relation.

Within living systems, relations become increasingly internal and organized around the organism's own continuation.

Within conscious systems, actuality can become directly related to itself.

Within reflective persons, the actuality can recognize its own historical trajectory and participate in directing it.

Thus Respect is not the mechanism that makes neurons emit consciousness.

It is the relational metaphysical order within which actualities can become increasingly internally related, increasingly unified, and increasingly capable of self-presence.

The progression is therefore:

Respect → relation → organization → internality → self-relation → consciousness.

The concept of Respect also preserves distinction. The fact that all actualities participate in one relational order does not mean they become one actuality.

Unity does not require identity.

Relation makes genuine distinction possible.

15. The Theological Horizon: Perfect Self-Presence

The framework finally yields a natural theological extension.

If finite consciousness is actuality becoming directly present to itself, then Perfect Actuality represents the limiting case.

A finite being achieves only partial self-presence. Its knowledge is incomplete. Its history is unfinished. Its possibilities exceed its present state.

God, understood as Perfect Actuality, would not merely possess consciousness as one property among others.

Perfect Actuality would be perfect self-presence.

There is no unrealized actuality behind God waiting to become what God might be.

The distinction between finite and divine self-presence remains absolute. Human consciousness is limited, embodied, temporal, and dependent. Divine self-presence is not.

Nevertheless, the same metaphysical grammar applies:

Finite consciousness is a limited mode of actuality's self-presence.

Divine consciousness is perfect actuality's perfect self-presence.

The theological conclusion therefore does not need to be imposed upon the theory from the beginning. It emerges as the completion of its metaphysical structure.

16. What Respectivism Claims—and What It Does Not

The philosophical strength of Respectivism depends upon keeping its claims precise.

It does not claim that every physical object is conscious.

It does not claim that consciousness is a primitive property possessed by every particle.

It does not claim that self-representation automatically produces experience.

It does not claim that neuroscience is unnecessary.

And it does not claim that merely defining consciousness as self-relation settles every philosophical question.

Its stronger claim is ontological:

The physical and phenomenal are not necessarily two independently existing realities. They can be two modes of description of one sufficiently organized actuality.

Its claim about subjectivity is then:

Subjectivity arises when actuality is organized around its own is–ought structure, so that its states are significant relative to its own possibilities.

Its claim about consciousness is:

Consciousness arises when that subjectivity becomes sufficiently unified and reflective for the actuality to enter into direct self-relation.

Its claim about the soul is:

The soul is the historically unified actuality through which a person becomes who they are.

And its claim about immortality is:

Because the temporal history through which a person is constituted is not rendered unreal by becoming past, that historical actuality is not simply reducible to nothing at biological death; its ultimate fulfillment, however, depends upon divine preservation and participation in Perfect Actuality.

These are distinct claims, but they arise from one metaphysical foundation.

17. Does This Really Solve the Hard Problem?

The most serious philosophical objection remains unavoidable:

Is Respectivism actually explaining consciousness, or merely redescribing it?

If one says, "*Consciousness is what actuality is like when it becomes self-present*," an opponent may reasonably reply:

"*Why should self-presence feel like anything?*"

This is the crucial remaining question.

Respectivism should not pretend that the question has disappeared entirely.

Its contribution is instead to show that the traditional explanatory gap may be generated by treating physical actuality and experience as separate ontological products.

If the physical brain state and the experience of that state are one actuality under different modes of description, then no causal mechanism needs to convert the former into the latter.

The original question—

How does matter produce experience?

—is dissolved.

But a narrower question remains:

Why does sufficiently organized direct self-relation possess a first-personal character?

Respectivism's answer is that first-personality is not something added to self-relation from outside.

It is the character of self-relation when the actuality doing the relating is the actuality being encountered.

In other words, the theory does not say:

self-relation + mysterious phenomenal ingredient = consciousness.

It says:

direct self-relation just is the actuality's phenomenal self-presence.

Whether this constitutes a satisfactory metaphysical explanation is the central question for further development.

I believe that is a considerably stronger position than simply declaring the hard problem solved.

18. The Unified Respectivist Picture of the Mental

The concepts developed throughout this account are not independent additions but successive dimensions of one metaphysical structure:

Actuality → is-ought → subjectivity → internal unity → direct self-relation → phenomenal self-presence → historical unity → soul → character → freedom → fulfillment.

Actuality provides the foundation. Its relation to its own possibilities establishes the is-ought structure through which states can become significant to the actuality itself. When this significance becomes sufficiently internally unified, actuality can enter into direct self-relation and phenomenal self-presence.

This is why consciousness is not merely information about a state. The is-ought structure gives an actuality an internally significant perspective: its states matter relative to what it is, what it has been, and what it can become. Unity brings these significant relations together within one actuality. When that sufficiently unified actuality becomes directly related to itself, there is not merely information about a state, but the actuality's own condition becoming present from within its own field of significance.

Thus, what it is like to be something is the first-personal character of a sufficiently unified actuality encountering itself through its own directed possibilities and developing significance that belongs to its own unique slice of actuality.

Across time, that continuing actuality forms a historical trajectory: the soul. The direction of that trajectory is character, while reflective participation in its direction is freedom. Immortality, in its fullest sense, concerns the preservation and fulfillment of that historical actuality through participation in Perfect Actuality.

Respectivism therefore treats consciousness, personhood, and immortality as connected dimensions of actuality becoming increasingly related to itself.

Ultimately, we are finite actualities awakening within an infinite horizon of being—temporary forms capable of turning inward, becoming present to themselves, and, through that self-relation, encountering the deeper reality from which all finite becoming receives its possibility.

We are not the Infinite.

Yet we stand within it.

We become ourselves within its depths.

And perhaps consciousness itself is the moment when the finite, without becoming infinite, becomes capable of turning toward the deeper ground of existence—

actuality becoming present to itself, within the Infinite.